Crash Landing

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General Audiences

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Crash Landing

by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

Prime has no need for defects, and sentences an aberration to exile in a prototype ship on the most distant edges of his empire. It never expected to fall into a shadow dimension below reality, crashing into an isolated planet there, and being forced back to health against its will.

Princess Entrapta is fascinated by the newcomer to her domain. They are completely unlike anyone else she has ever met. For one, he wishes to know about her theories. That he fell from the sky in a ship so far more advanced than anything on Etheria is equally as enticing.

OR

Hordak crashes into Dryll at the start of the series instead of long before. Written based on a Tumblr post by morallygrayautisticscientist with their permission.

Chapter 1: Damaged Pilot

Prime's empire had extended without pause for hundreds of years, constantly striving towards universal peace and harmony. And there was no room for imperfection in his empire if it was to achieve this. Which is why it troubled him that he could feel a faint aberration in his horde. Worse, it was nearby.

"… You," Prime narrowed his eyes, staring at a face beside his throne. "Come here." The clone approached, quivering with joy at being this close to his might. Except for one fact,

Prime grabbed the failure by the throat, lifting it from the floor. Metallic talons snagged the tunic sleeve, ripping it clear off. Emerald blood oozed from lines left in the wake, but that was the least of his worries. Dark tendrils were faintly spreading out from the chest, more revealed as he tore the torso exposed. "*Defective.*" He snarled. A flaw in the cloning process. Maybe as simple as a misplaced nucleotide at one of the earlier stages, only manifesting now, long after this impurity had been at his side.

"Lord Prime, please!" It begged. "I am still loyal!"

"Fret not," Prime dropped the disgusting, mewling mess to the floor. It knew what was coming, what happened to all of its ilk. "All beings have a place in my empire." Two more clones approached, lifting the aberration under each arm, and dragging it along.

It was fortuitous timing. There was a prototype ship that required testing. Without a living subject, he would be unable to determine the affects of the experimental drive might have on the clones. While his hordes were not limited, it would be wasteful to build ships that would only cause additional resources to be expended.

"Rejoice," He smiled as the defect was thrust towards the ship. "We acknowledge your efforts. Go now, and join your brothers on the battlefield." Prime watched with clear delight as the flaw was

forced into the cockpit, straps tugged into place, and the engines powering up as it stared mournfully. The ship blurred from the hanger, and he took pleasure from knowing that the mistake would be aware of his satisfaction at watching it leave. Making a mental note to check on the ship once it arrived at the far destination, he coldly began returning to his throne room.

"Log: day sixty-seven… sixty-eight?" A tendril of hair curled the recorder closer to her mask as she tinkered with her equipment. "First Ones artifact number forty-two appeared to be a form of power convertor. Which kind was unclear, but the recoverable fragments were able to sustain the full charge from my laboratory with no signs of strain! If this technology could be replicated, the potential uses are limitless!" Princess Entrapta of Dryll put aside her soldering iron to examine the connections. "I've replaced as many of the missing segments as I can. If I'm right, I should be able to store the equivalent of two hours of Dryll's entire power usage without any ill-effects." Flipping her welding mask down, she retreated to a safe distance.

Five metres was safe, right?

Eh, it was good enough to flip a switch without any of the stray volts from grounding near her!

Entrapta watched the numbers of transferred power climb with unparalleled glee. Artifact forty-two was probably her greatest achievement yet! Her only other specimen of comparable completeness was a green tri-pointed crystal that appeared mostly intact yet had no interfaces that she could see. Maybe she could build one, after this experiment was completed.

"Edit to log; we have just passed one day of power usage," She whispered in hushed tones. Lights were dimming and flickering as the power grid struggled to keep up with the unceasing drain of resources. "My additions are responding within expected parameters. *This is so exciting!*" A single spark flickered from the boundary between modern and ancient tech. "Uh-oh."

Entrapta lunged behind the nearest storage container a fraction before the explosion ripped through her lab. "Edit to log:" Entrapta repeated, even though she couldn't hear past the ringing in her ears. "It appears that the energy balance between First Ones and modern tech requires further refinement." Pinching her nose, she flexed her throat muscles several times until her ear drums popped. The ringing wouldn't fully stop for a few hours, but it was fading to background noise. "Artifact forty-two is not a viable component for merging with modern tech, but it could provide a template for a new capacitor model."

Another rumble shook the world, and she lifted her mask.

"Weird, the other versions only exploded once," She mused. "And that rumbling sounds more like an earthquake." The recorder clicked at her side. "Experimental capacitor may have caused an earthquake. If true, this is *fascinating* progress." Hair gripping onto cables and beams, the inventor swung to a high window to examine the world outside the laboratory. It was usually unimportant, merely a source of materials for further scientific progress, yet there was a difference today that piqued their interest.

"Update: the sky is on fire."

It had been lamenting, cursing the weakness that had lain dormant within it as the ship flew through the empty void between the stars, when the space around it had ripped open, a void within a void. No stars. No signals. No signs of Prime.

And there, in this reality beneath reality, was a planet, ringed by numerous moons. For a single moment, it thought the sight resplendent. No sun, no stars, only the gentle radiance of the moons around a planet nearly entirely filled with water. One landmass that it could see, spiralling across all the major habitats. Desert, tundras, greenery. So simple, so intricate.

But this was impossible! Prime was infallible. Unless…

A test! A way to prove worthy. To find this planet and report back to Prime! Joy flooded the clone, wondrous rapture as it beheld the opportunity for redemption.

Then the ship was caught in the gravity, drawn in as systems began failing.

The ground was coming up too fast! Controls unresponsive, afflicted by an unknown interference. Prime has entrusted it with this ship, to see that they reached the distant battlefield in full functionality. It would not fail, it *could* not fail!

It repeated that mantra as the atmosphere ignited around the ship.

A second impact roused it, a first having concussed and confused. Flashes of blinding light and paralysing darkness each time head met surface. Screeches of metal and crumbling rocks sounds from all around, as the ship lanced across the rocky domain.

Mountains. Minerals. Resources. It made note of that as the ship ricocheted again, heading towards the rocky surface. It wasn't possible to avoid, even if it could steer the ship.

Impact had knocked it unconscious, but the burning air briefly roused it. This atmosphere was toxic, painful.

A… *thing* was looming over him. A metallic faceplate obscuring its visage as the darkness closed back in. "Hello," A nasal voice announced. "Who are you?"

It could feel tiny marks impacting the cranium. Sensors or some kind. It shuffled, blearily reaching up a hand to confirm a tangle of wires. Its brothers must have been tending to it while it was unconscious.

"… een. Subject appears to be steadily regaining conscious in increasing durations."

This voice was unfamiliar. It was lesser, alone.

Darkness closed in again, wresting away the light of Prime.

It forced back to consciousness again. There was an outline over it. Blurry, but distinctly smaller. Not a brother.

Yet they looked down at it with an expression of such wonder and elation that he knew of only one possible cause in all of the cosmos.

"Prime?" A flicker of joy sharpened the world for a moment longer.

"Prime?" The indistinct face repeated. "Is that a person? Are you asking for something? Are you talking about numbers? Are you a scientist? You'd have to be, to make a ship that good. But I don't recognise the markings, maybe it's,"

Despair dragged it back down into the darkness. This world was truly a nightmare, to not know of Prime's mercy.

It awoke. Truly wakefulness, for the first time.

How long had it been? Long enough that the body was ailing. Prime has described this condition of the lesser beings he sought to save. Hunger. "Nutrient… vat." If the stranger was nearby, they could bring it to a vat for nourishment.

"Don't worry, I've got all that you need right here." An uncoiling surface slid it upright, and something was shoved through the oral cavity.

It was disgustingly warm, slithering down the throat, filling the inside. The first mouthful had been swallowed on reflex, the second was spat out across the floor. "Is it too hot?" There was a

strange slurping sound. "Nope, that's right. Do you not like chicken soup? That's crazy - everyone likes chicken soup!"

Another portion was forced inside, and it was with dreadful horror that the feeling of… *hunger* began to abate. The unfamiliar sensation was beginning to grow not unpleasant. May Prime's light end this unnatural aberration!

"What's your name?" The blurry figure demanded. "You look male, are you male?"

"I am one of many," It rasped. "Part of all."

"You sound male," The voice continued. Prime, this one was insufferable! "Where did you come from? I've checked my database, there's nothing like you on all of Etheria! It made treating your injuries a bit of an experiment, but I had some duct tape around that wasn't going to the ducts any time soon."

Ducts? Then, this world was advanced enough to have technology? "Etheria?" An unfamiliar word.

"Uh, yeah?" The blurred figure shifted back. "Wow, how hard did you hit your head? Don't answer that," Another shape waved past. "I already calculated the concussive force. Your ship took some scoring on the underside, and I was able to gather samples. The tests are,"

"Ship?!" It gasped, fighting the approaching smells of warm meat. "My ship?"

Wrong! All belonged only to Prime!

"Uh-huh," Another mouthful was forced inside, and it reluctantly swallowed. "I brought it to my lab. It's really something. There's some bits missing, I think, so I scavenged all the parts that I could find."

"Show me." It commanded.

"Oh, are you feeling up for a walk?"

The light faded as the ground rushed up.

It was humiliating. A wheeled contrivance! *Wheels!* This, this *pest* had forced him into a crude, *wheeled* seat. If there was a greater shame than enduring this obsolete technology, it was not apparent.

No, the shame of continuing to rely upon this prattling being was the greater shame. "We have been moving through these halls all day!" He raged. "When do we reach the ship?!"

"I'm not sure." The pusher announced. "I usually have my map with me."

"Bah!" He made to stand, but was suddenly restrained into the contraption by *hair* of all things. This insipid being had somehow learned to move what was, on most species, mere dead cells. It was interesting, in a way.

"Nope, you're not ready for the big walks - remember what happened last time?"

He grunted, reluctantly allowing the inferior being to continue moving about the halls. It was another symptom of the weakness that he felt himself growing fatigued far faster than it should, and a deep, slow, exhale forced its way out.

"Oh, you're tired?" How could this mere pusher of chairs know such a thing? "Don't worry, we'll get you back to sleep, and see the ship first thing in the morning!"

No matter how he yelled and struggled, the moving hair simply contained its struggles as the chair rotated on the spot. "Don't worry!" The pusher insisted. "I promise not to mess with your ship."

The clone scoffed, aware that no being would ever meddle with that which belonged to Prime.

Except… This being had never heard of Prime.

"What have you done to my ship?!" He demanded.

"Don't get mad," She warned it. "But I maybe, possibly, put as much of it back together as I could."

All reason for aggression faded. She had sought to serve Prime. That was noble. "Left." He growled.

"If you say so." She turned the way she was told, happily following the curve of the hallway. "Hey, you're right!"

"Right." He commanded.

"Yes, you're right."

"*No,*" He growled. "It was that right turn that we passed." They swung around again, taking the next identical hallway.

"Wow, you really know your way around."

Another slow breath forced itself out, and the clone drooped in the soft embrace. Hair was supposed to be dead, decayed cells capable of nothing. This enclosure felt warm, soothing like a nutrient vat beneath the gaze of Prime.

"Aww," Entrapta cooed as her guest slumped over. She continued down the hallway for a few seconds, softly admiring her passenger. "Which way now?" She asked as they reached a crossroads. The only response was a slight shifting in the nest of her hair.

He glared from where he had been propped upright in a bed. It was not an unfamiliar item, there were some on the Velvet Glove for the truly honoured, but no clone had ever used one before.

Worse, to be fed this warm concoction of proteins by a small ladle wielded personally by a lower being.

"Show me to the ship." He demanded.

"My name's Entrapta." This stranger didn't flinch as the bowl exploded across the room. "What's your name?" She smiled, chin propped in hands propped on knees, somehow suspended on her hair.

"I do not have a name." It scowled. Names were precious gifts, granted by Prime only to those planets that were deemed worthy of joining his empire. "I serve Prime faithfully! Fight for him! Carry out his will! Prime, leader of the boundless Horde, *acknowledged* me in my parting!"

"If you would like, I can call you 'The one who Prime, leader of the boundless Horde, acknowledged'?"

"That will suffice." It coldly informed her.

"Okay!" She dropped down to the floor. "I'll call you Hordak for short!"

"I said that I do not have a name!" He roared, struggling to be free of the covers that wrapped around him.

"Well, it might not be your name, but it's something that you'll know means I want to talk to you," The inferior creature busied itself again, mask flipped down as it turned attention to a data pad. "That's not so bad, is it?"

The clone glared angrily. It was one of countless others, a face in the faceless masses. Yet here, on this insufferable backwater planet, caught in a shadow dimension, it was alone in the mission of bringing them into Prime's light. "It is… acceptable as a means of identification." Hor… *the clone* growled in acquiescence. "Now, show me to the ship."

He allowed himself to be inserted into the wheelchair once more, carted through the endless identical halls. Entrapta had him hold the data pad, a map navigating their path. It was not until they reached her laboratory that he allowed himself to feel dread. How had her efforts affected the ship? What fresh horrors might await his growing list of failures.

"This is…" Worse than he feared. Entire panels had been crushed upon impact, yet more carefully unpieced from the ship by more cautious hands. Segments dismantled and carefully laid out, innards exposed. Prime would be furious, forsaking him. Shock overrode Hordak's pain, and he forced himself from the chair, approaching the wreckage.

"I know!" And Entrapta sounded delighted more than anything. "It's the most advanced technology I've seen since First Ones tech!"

"First Ones?" An unusual name. One that he could distract himself with as he examined the remains of his, of *Prime's* ship.

"They were a race of beings who disappeared a thousand years ago," Entrapta intoned in a dramatic voice. "Nobody knows where they went, or what they looked like, but they say that they came from the stars and took the stars with them when they left."

Hordak paused, a hand still gripping a fragmented bulkhead. These… First Ones. They had moved an entire planetary system into this empty shadow dimension? Such a fear was not beyond Prime, but to have done it a millennia ago, when his empire was younger, would have been difficult. "Tell me more." He demanded.

"You want to hear more about my experiments?" Entrapta rushed up beside him.

"They are potentially useful," He glared. "Why would I not wish to hear about them?"

"People," She flipped the mask down. "People don't really listen to my theories. They don't understand me. Like, these capacitors

I've been working." She thrust her pad up to his face. "They're decades ahead of anything else the Makers Guild are working on."

"These capacitors," He slowly rotated the design. "Do you believe that you could make more?"

"Oh, absolutely!" Entrapta cheered up as they . "They just have a tendency to explode when I try."

"Doubtless a fault in your materials." Hordak dismissed the concern.

"That's what I figured," She admitted. "But there's a limit to what I have to work with. Some of the fragments I collected from your ship are made from materials I've never seen before."

He scoffed, wondering how truly despondent Entrapta must be as the greatest mind on a backwater planet. "I shall provide you with the information required for synthesising greater materials than your paltry planet has ever known," He growled. "Together, we shall repair this ship, and construct technologies the likes of which your people have never dreamed!"

"You want to be lab partners?" Entrapta shyly lifted her mask. "I've never had a lab partner before."

Hordak glared down at this unusual person. Cut off from the hive mind, he retained only that information shared with all. How nearly all of the lower beings that were graced with Prime's presence were chaotic, conflicted beings, incapable of putting logic and reason above their pathetic base squabbles. It would appear that Entrapta was one of the rare few worthy of being more.

"We shall do great things together." Hordak smiled as she rose opposite him.

Chapter 2: Visitors

Chapter Summary

> Princess Entrapta has been neither heard nor seen in months, and Bright Moon is concerned. Dispatching their most trained soldier, she decides to take a shortcut through the Whispering Woods, wherein she crosses paths with an unlikely adventurer to complete the journey.

"Adora, I would like you to visit Dryll," Angella announced as they took their morning walk. Glimmer was studying magic with Micah, and the pairs had long since fallen into a routine of running their activities in parallel. "I have some concerns about the state of their affairs."

"What's wrong?" Adora asked seriously.

Angella glanced at her in concern. "Princess Entrapta has not been heard from in nearly six months," She revealed. "Her staff insist that she is unharmed, but nobody outside her castle has had any direct contact with her. And there are concerning rumours about a visitor who arrived right before the changes in her behaviour."

"I'm not sure what you want me to do." Adora confessed.

Angella sighed. "Neither am I," She confessed. "I simply feel that something is amiss. New materials are being ordered to the Crypto Castle, and there has been a remarkably lower rate of explosions heard by the citizens." Only in Dryll could word of fewer explosions be a warning sign.

"I'll pack a bag and head out." The young warrior promised.

Glimmer found her as she was packing. "Let me come with you." She begged. There were no secrets in the family. Even if they tried, Adora was dressed in trousers, boots, and a functional jacket as she packed a bag.

"Sorry Glim," Adora smiled. "You know what Juliet says - more unnecessary people, more unnecessary risk."

"General Juliet says that about civilians and bandits," There was so little danger on Etheria that the traditional guard occupying Bright Moon were going through the motions more months than not. Juliet was a soldier without a war, refining tactics to a razor edge that was carving banditry out of the kingdom with surgical precision. "What's the worst that can happen?"

"Listen to your aunt when she tells you want to do." Adora taunted.

"Ugh!" Glimmer groaned. "You were barely with Light Spinner for a few days before she gave you to Mom and Dad! "

"Still counts," Adora smirked. Then she stopped. "I'll only be gone a week - long enough to get to Dryll, find out what's going on, and come back."

"I wish that I had my full powers already," Glimmer whined. "I could be in Dryll and back in a blink."

"We don't all need powers." Adora grumbled, and Glimmer winced. Being the only non-magical one in a family full of Princesses and mages must have been hard enough without her finder and grandmother figure repeatedly claiming that she had magic of her own.

"Are you taking Horsey?" She shifted topics.

"Quickest way to Dryll is through the Whispering Woods," Adora reminded her. "I don't want to spook him going through there if he doesn't have to. I'll call as soon as I arrive - if there's anything weird going on, you, Mom, Dad, and Horsey will be right there." She tightened the straps on her bag.

"Why don't I come along as backup?" Glimmer tried again.

"It's a simple scouting mission," Adora shrugged the straps into place, and laid a comforting hand on her shoulder. "I'll call you when I reach Dryll, and then I'll call you as soon as I know what's going on - I promise."

"Don't see what the big deal is," She grumpily folded her arms. "Dryll's only got a bunch of crazy scientists to it."

"Oh?" Adora raised a knowing eyebrow. "Is *that* why you want to go?"

"Shut up!" Glimmer blushed, disappearing in a cloud of sparkles.

The creatures of the Whispering Woods were skitterish, avoiding most travellers. It was rare to encounter difficulty when travelling through.

Unless you believed the rumours that no traces were left.

Adora was starting to believe those stories as she sprinted around a massive trunk. She wished she had listened to Glimmer, or at least could use the magic Light Spinner promised that she had. Instead, she was fleeing from the massive insect creature behind her. She was comparably lucky - it was only twice the size of a horse, not five times like some of the others she had seen.

"*Why* are you chasing me?!" She demanded. "It's not like I did anything wrong!" A mandible sliced through a root bigger than her head and she sped up.

Something flew past her, exploding against the creature in a cloud of blinding smoke that clawed at her eyes and filled her lungs with fire. "Come on!" A voice called low in the cloud, grabbing her by one hand, and tugging her away. "Here," Adora's eyes were still blurring as she saw a handful of greenery ripped from a bush and aggressively rubbed over her jacket. "This will mask your scent for a while, long enough to get away."

Adora was dragged further into the Woods, propped against a tree when they reached a clearing. "Thank you."

"You should," The voice retorted as she scrubbed her eyes clear. "What's a nice girl like you doing wandering around my forest?"

Adora's stomach clenched at the familiar phrases, and she stared at the stabilising figure in shock. "*Catra?*" She blinked in amazement.

"Hey Adora." She smirked, leaning a massive sword over one shoulder. "What are you doing this deep in the Woods?"

"Heading to Dryll. I thought I could save time cutting deeper through the forest. Looks like I was wrong." Adora admitted. "That's a new look," She gestured to the broadsword Catra was slinging around. "Where did you get it?"

"This old thing?" Catra innocently hefted the crystal blade. "Found it right before you pissed off the skitter."

"I swear that I've seen it somewhere before." Adora stared in rapt attention.

"Yeah, George and Lance have a drawing of one in their library," Catra shrugged. "I'm thinking of giving it to them - for a fair price, of course."

"Of course." Adora rolled her eyes. Catra was a natural warrior, and accompanied Bow's parents on their excavations sometimes. No matter how lacklustre the excursion, she always seemed to end up justifying being paid more than originally agreed.

"What's the reward for escorting Bright Moon royalty through dangerous territory to a potentially hostile land?" Catra dug the sword into the ground, casually leaning on it as she inspected her claws.

"What makes you think Dryll is hostile?" Adora interrogated. Catra kept one ear tuned to gossip, she might have heard something

relevant.

"You're wearing your practical trousers," Catra flicked a finger at Adora's clothing. "You only wear them when it's necessary."

"How do you know what I wear?" Adora blinked.

Catra instantly shifted to a flustered scowl. "Do you want me to show you the way to Dryll or not?" She snapped, cheeks reddening.

"I do!" Adora blurted. The insect had taken her staff and shattered it like a toothpick - Catra and her sword were the only defence she would have. Besides, Catra was the est tracker on Etheria, and one of her best friends.

"It's this way." Clutching the sword, Catra pointed to her left and set course. Adora hurried after her, quickly falling into place. "I'm surprised that Glimmer and Bow aren't with you." Catra casually announced as they proceeded through the Woods.

"It's a scouting mission, Glimmer doesn't need to come along," Adora explained. "And why would Bow be here?" Catra stared at Adora until she backed down from her ridiculous question. Any time Glimmer left Bright Moon, she went out of her way to ask Bow along.

They made camp in a small hollow. Adora dug a hole to build a small fire, while Catra caught, killed, and skinned a pair of rodents for dinner. It was hardly the gourmet cooking of Bright Moon, but her rations had been used to distract the bug on her tail - a fact that Catra was only too willing to mock her for.

"Sure would have been easier if you'd had the sort of magic the rest of the family has." She had bluntly summarised.

"Light Spinner says that I'm some sort of Princess," Adora admitted, prodding the small fire with a stick. "She's done tests,

and rituals, and says that I have magic in me, but there's something blocking it."

"Light Spinner?" Catra blinked.

"She's the one who found me as a baby," Adora explained. "She sensed a magical disturbance, and found me in a field. Her apprentice, King Micah, was expecting a child with Queen Glimmer, and they thought it best that I grow up with a normal family."

"Normal family?" Catra smirked. "King Mage, Queen Tall, and Princess Sparkles?" Adora burst out laughing. "What?"

"Princess Sparkles?" She echoed. "I dare you to call her that at the All Princess Ball."

"Princess Prom?" Catra raised an eyebrow. "I'm great at getting into places, but sneaking into Princess Prom isn't worth the risk."

"It's not sneaking in if you're invited." Adora pointed out. "Princesses get a plus-one."

"Hmmm, I could ask Scorpia," Catra glanced sideways. The light flickering across Adora's face made for interesting viewing. "She likes my stories when I pass through her kingdom."

"I thought she was going with Perfuma?" Adora blinked.

"I'm fine sharing." Catra shrugged, going back to staring at the fire.

"Why don't you just come with me?" Adora blurted.

"Hmm," Catra mused playfully. "If I don't get a better offer. Who knows? Maybe Sparkles will invite me along."

"Then I'll take Bow and see you there." Adora glared. She knew that Catra was toying with her, but two could play at that game.

"I'm sure that you'll enjoy the party with Glimmer while Bow and I make her jealous."

Catra gave a throaty laugh that filled Adora with a warmth greater than the fire.

Adora awoke like the tide creeping up the shore. Juliet had trained her to not react to a potentially hostile environment until she was fully aware of the situation, to remain quiet and placid so as not to alert any nefarious elements. Currently, there was an unexpected weight against one side, comforting warmth sapping at her desire to wake. Next, was the steady rumble, resonating in her chest and aching her heart. Otherwise, she could detect nothing different about their surroundings from the previous night.

She opened her eyes, staring at the figure pressed to her side. "Catra?" She breathed, carefully dusting back a strand of hair.

Catra stiffened, the purring giving way to a sour grunt as she forced her eyes open. Then she saw Adora watching her. "'Bout time you woke up," She yawned, stretching up. "Come on," Gathering her sword, she reached down her spare hand for the adopted Princess. "Let's get going."

Over the next few days of travel, they feel into a confusing yet comfortable routine. Adora would wake first, watching in marvel at the figure pressed against her side. When Catra woke, she would yawn, spend a moment deliberately pressed to her side, and then order a start to the day. After scavenging up breakfast, they would resume their journey.

Come the third evening, Adora could dimly spot Dryll castle in the distance. "We can make it tonight, if we keep pushing." She decided.

"Or," Catra unbuckled her sword, dropping it to one side. "We can get a full night's rest, and be ready for whatever's waiting up

there."

"I'm here to find out why Entrapta hasn't been heard from," Adora snapped. Catra had a lackadaisical attitude at times, but this was *important*. "And that means,"

"That means running headlong into a situation when you've been walking for days, you have no idea what's waiting for you, and you're tired." Catra yawned theatrically. "You go ahead, I'll get some rest, and come and rescue you in the morning."

Adora glanced up at the castle. Then at the infuriating women casually arranging herself for another night on the floor.

"I promised Glimmer that I would call her tonight," She explained. "My pad was lost with the rest of her stuff when that bug found me, the only way I can contact her is by getting to Dryll."

"What do you think she'd prefer," Catra folded both arms behind her head, and closed her eyes. "You rushing into danger tired, or waiting until morning?"

Adora grumbled, settling down onto the rocky ground. "It's cold." She grumbled, tugging her jacket closer.

"What did you expect?" Catra smirked without opening her eyes. "Dryll is all rock, it doesn't have trees or greenery to keep heat in."

Adora say up angrily. "I'm going to start a fire."

"Good idea," Her companion taunted. "Alert those potential enemies with a nice glaring beacon." Adora scowled, but lay back down anyway. It was freezing, right until Catra rolled over, sprawling across her side.

"Stars," Adora breathed. "How are you this warm?"

"Fur?" Even without looking, she would have known that Catra's face was showing that smug little smile. But Adora was looking,

because it was wonderful to see. "Go to sleep," She ordered, tugging Adora to roll against her. "We've got a busy day tomorrow."

"Nnngh," Catra groaned, shuffling in closer. "Five more minutes!" For a busy day, she was reluctant to get started.

"No, *now!*" Adora pried her arm from Catra's back.

"Fine," Catra rolled away, snatching sword and moving upright in fluid movement. "But you'd better not dawdle on the way back."

"You're coming back to Bright Moon with me?" Adora felt her heart pounding in her chest loud enough to drown out the peculiar noise.

"Only to stop you from getting lost," Catra smirked. "After that?" She shrugged. "Who knows?" Not Adora, but she couldn't wait to find out.

The road to Dryll was unremarkable, except for one very remarkable furrow gouged along the path and into the mountainside.

"Rock slide." Catra observed.

"First rockslide I've ever seen that has metal in it." Adora observed a small sliver by her boot.

"Some sort of experiment gone wrong?" Catra crouched on all fours, sniffing the ground. "I hear that her experiments explode… a lot." Adora had heard the same.

The courtyard entrance to the Crypto Castle wasn't overflowing, but it was also far from as populous as Bright Moon.

"Well, they're not dead," Catra casually observed. "Nobody seems to be oppressed either. I guess we can go."

"Excuse me," Adora smiled at a civilian. "Can you tell me where Princess Entrapta is?"

They looked at her like she had asked where the moons were. "In her lab." Response came in a similar tone. "In the castle?"

Adora thanked them for their time, and turned to see Catra's disgruntled expression. "You smile weird when you try." She stated frankly.

Without an answer to offer, the pair entered the castle. "So?" She glared around at the various openings. "Which way is it?" Silence. Catra looked at Adora in confusion. "You *do* know where it is? Don't you?"

Adora swallowed. "It's this way." She said decisively. Catra followed her down the hallway. Though she could have sworn they were walking in a straight line, they somehow ended up back in the entry vestibule. No, not exactly - there was no door leading outside.

"I heard rumours about this place," Catra scowled. "I didn't expect anyone to be crazy enough to design their entire castle to be a maze."

"It's not the entire castle." A nasally voice casually announced.

Catra yowled, leaping clear onto Adora's shoulders. The pair collapsed, tumbling beneath the dispassionate gaze of a metal mask. "Hello!" It waved, a covered tray in one hand.

"Princess Entrapta!" Adora gasped. "You're okay!"

"Why wouldn't I be?" She tilted her head.

"Because you haven't been heard from in six months?" Adora clambered to her feet as Catra rotated in a showy flip.

"Oh?" Entrapta turned. "Has it really been that long?" She pulled out a recorder. "Update to log: It has reportedly been six months

since work with Hordak began. Two visitors to my castle have confirmed as such. This is *fascinating* - it confirms that enjoyment drastically alters perception of time!"

"Princess Entrapta?" Adora circled to enter her field of view. "Who's Hordak?"

"Oh, Hordak? Come on, I'll introduce you!" Catra made a noise like 'grruunnghh!' as Entrapta suddenly leaned up on her hair and began striding off down the corridor.

"Does she do that a lot?!" She whispered to Adora.

"Entrapta can control her hair," She whispered back. "She uses it for all sorts of things."

"Hey, Entrapta!" Catra called. "How do you move your hair like that?"

"Like what?" Entrapta swung around to face them, still swinging backwards as she went. Catra shrugged, unable to decided how best to articulate her question.

"Princess Entrapta?" Adora butted in. "Is this 'Hordak' the reason that you've not been heard from?"

"Yep!" She cheered, swinging back around. "We're working together!"

Catra noticed the shock cross Adora's face. "What?" She whispered.

"Entrapta works alone," She explained. "She's never worked with someone for more than a few days before." Her eyes flicked to the sword on Catra's back.

"I'll follow your lead." She promised.

"We're here!" Entrapta cheered.

Adora had seen less terrifying doors in the vaults at Bright Moon, or the enchanted prisons at Mystacor where unruly apprentices were made to reflect on their actions. "Nice digs," Catra grinned. "What are you keeping locked in there?"

"Huh?" Entrapta blinked owlishly up at them. "Oh, these are to keep anything in, they're to keep the people out."

Catra caught Adora's eye, and shifted the handle of the sword to where she could grab it if events spiralled the way they anticipated. For all Entrapta's explanation that she was only keeping people locked out, it sounded awfully like she was keeping something locked in.

The doors whirred open with a piercing screech. "One of the wheels came off in an explosion," Entrapta yelled the explanation. "We'll fix it."

An explosion big enough to shake these doors? What was inside the dimly lit room.

Robots. Row of machinery. Pinpricks of light dancing around every surface. And a single, looming outline.

"I'm back!" Entrapta swung happily into the room, rushing to the forboding figure.

"That much is obvious," It snarled like a wounded animal. "Who are these people?" Such little light filled the room that the scowling eyes seemed to glow as they settled on the pair by the door. Catra felt the fur along her spine tighten and raise in instinctive reaction.

"These are my friends," Entrapta beamed. "Uh," She turned to face them. "What are your names again?"

"*This* is Her Royal Highness, Princess Adora of Bright Moon," Catra bowed a sweeping arm to introduce her companion. "And I'm Catra." She smirked at Adora's embarrassed and frustrated expression. "Just Catra."

"Princess Adora," Hordak growled by way of welcome as the lightshow was cutoff. "Just Catra." Catra's smirk instantly migrated over to Adora's face as more normal lighting flickered on. "I am Hordak."

The name rang around the room dramatically. "Cool," Catra breezed aside. "Where did you get the constellation map?"

Surprise flickered across his face. "What do *you* know of constellations?" He demanded suspiciously. Nobody else on this backwater planet had shown awareness before now.

Whatever answer Catra may have returned was slaughtered beneath a cacophony of noise and flashing lights.

"What's that?!" Adora yelled, layering both hands over Catra's as they gripped her sensitive ears.

Hordak slammed an enraged fist onto a panel, shutting off the overwhelming noise. "An alarm clock." He sneered. "We are done with work for this period." Bending down, he roughly wrapped an arm around Entrapta's midriff, and pulled her into the air.

"Nnnoooooo!" Entrapta stiffled a yawn, struggling towards the workbench. "The data,"

"Can *wait* until *tomorrow*!" Hordak growled, fighting against the tendrils. "We have an agreement!"

"What agreement?" Adora demanded.

"We take a rest break every thirty-seven hours, at the latest." Hordak groaned, wobbling as she tried wrapping her hair around his limbs.

"It's only been thirty-six!" Entrapta yelled, fastening to the edges of the laboratory door as he slowly powered through.

"We still require nutrition and preparation for the sleep!" The slender man roared, forging ahead.

"Entrapta?" Adora slipped under her tendrils of hair. "Are you only sleeping every two days?"

"No!" She whined. "Thirty-seven hours is less than two days!"

"Entrapta, you can't sleep that little!" Adora began tugging at the locks.

"I can!" She yelled. "Science waits for no-one!"

"Entrapta!" Hordak roared, grabbing a pad, and thrusting it into her face. "We have examined the data, and reached consensus - the most efficient model is if with both rest at periods of thirty seven hour intervals!"

"… Data never lies." She slumped under a storm of resigned muttering.

Hordak grunted, shifting her to one arm. "It is not conducive to your functionality to rest so little," He snapped. "Your focus drops off after twenty-five hours."

"But I can prevent that by taking regular rest intervals of thirty minutes each at intervals of four hours." The uncontested most brilliant member of the Etherian Makers Guild complained.

"And I can function at even great efficiency for longer," Hordak retorted. "These extensive periods you require are mere fragments to myself."

"How little are you two sleeping?" Catra asked in obvious concern as they walked down another identical corridor.

"We sleep ten hours after every thirty-seven, and take two days off after ten cycles," Entrapta seemed perfectly content to lay splayed across his shoulders, hair entwined around limbs as Hordak stomped down the hallway. "That way, we have time to think up new ideas while we get ready for them."

"When you say that you rest for two days," Adora began.

"We reset our laboratory for the next endeavour." Such a question seemed like an affront to the irritable scientist. "These are the guest quarters," Hordak directed the intruders to the pair of interlopers. "Make use of them until you leave."

"Really?" Entrapta blinked. "I thought they were the storage lockers for old parts."

"Those are a level down, on the other side of the castle." He rebuked.

Entrapta frowned, rotating a map on her pad to examine the schematics. "Huh." She mused. "I wonder where I put my snacks then." Catra looked down at the tray still held in a gloved hand. She could easily believe that Entrapta had been awake nearly two days.

"Princess Entrapta, can I borrow you pad to call Bright Moon?" Adora asked politely. "I need to report back to the Queen."

"You assured me that our work would have autonomy." Hordak turned to glare at the welding mask. It was difficult, when their faces were an inch apart, to imply the sort of aura Prime had so easily cast upon the lower words. Perhaps it was that distance that had allowed them to appreciate his full majesty. And that was why Hordak and his brethren were to mingle with the lower beings - to observe them on a more fitting scale.

Hordak was pleased that, even in his exile to these primitive conditions, he was still able to faithfully serve Prime's will.

"Queen Angella has no wish to interfere," The yellow-haired one interrupted. "We were worried because we hadn't heard from Entrapta in so long. Since we know that she's alright, we won't be bothering you again."

Hordak stared at the young female. This was an attempt to find and recover a lost member of a collective who possessed immense value. Prime would employ such tactics. If… if he could prove worthy, Prime would come for him. "We shall not let such

an incident happen again." Hordak informed her. Adora, that was her name. She would serve well in Prime's empire one day.

Catra followed Adora with a grin as she started a call to report in.

"Adora!" Glimmer burst out as soon as she was on the screen. "Are you okay? You were meant to call last night!"

"I lost my bag in the Whispering Woods, and didn't reach Dryll until this morning," Adora soothed her fears. "We've spoken to Entrapta, she's alright."

"Thank goodness," Glimmer sighed. "Why hasn't she been heard from in so long then?"

"She's got a boyfriend," Catra leaned happily on Adora's shoulder. "Sup, Sparkles?"

"Glimmer, you remember Catra," Adora forced a smile into place as she introduced her new companion. "She works with Bow and his dads sometimes?"

"Oooooh, *you're* the Princess that his folks are always going on about," She grinned as Glimmer began spluttering. "I was wondering why Adora hadn't mentioned a boyfriend."

"Boyf" Glimmer quickly resembled a tomato as Adora tried shoving Catra out of frame again.

"Hey, does that mean she's single?" For adoptive siblings, there was an unmistakable resemblance in their complexions as Catra snatched the tablet away.

"Catra!" Adora gasped twice as hard as most people, since she had twice the reasons. "I need to finish reporting in!"

"You don't know the whole story." Catra interrupted.

Adora paused. "What did I miss?" She'd made sure to mentally note everything they'd come across. Hordak was unusual, yes, but

Etheria had a wide diversity of peoples.

"That projection he was looking at - I've only seen those lights in one other place," Catra flatly revealed. "George and Lance dug up an intact First Ones device. It has a few different images on it, but they're all of the same things; lights in the sky that they call,"

"Stars." Adora blurted the sentence complete.

Catra fell silent. "You've seen it before?" She asked, disappointed.

"No, I," Adora pressed a hand to her head. "I *remember* them from somewhere."

"Where?" Catra demanded. "They don't exist. George and Lance say they disappeared a thousand years ago."

"I don't know," Adora confessed. "I think I saw them once."

Catra considered the shaken expression on Adora's face. "Maybe seeing the other projector will help you remember?" She offered, laying a careful hand on her shoulder.

After a terrified moment of staring at the touch, Adora gently reciprocated. "I'd like that." She smiled.

It would be a small detour on the way back to Bright Moon. Unless they found reasons to keep travelling thereafter.

To have a chamber entirely for sleeping was not unusual to the clone. In times past, he had waited in an alcove in a chamber with his brothers. But that had been an altogether different experience. A clone at rest was another voice in the hive mind, sharing, learning, being one with all. The first few times that Hordak had slept, the sheer nothingness had erupted him into panicked screaming. Entrapta had not truly understood the terror, being of a singular mind, but had offered to watch over him in protection while he lay defenceless. They now shared a chamber, to aid each other should any incidents happen.

Hordak donned a softer robe for his slumber. He had found the stimulus of his waking apparel one that taunted him with ideas of working, instead of allowing this insipid resting that showed him as a flawed aberration. Forgoing the uncomfortable reminder was worth the temporary shame of wearing what Entrapta had told him was called a "onesie". Despite the illogical name, her argument of efficiency and pockets were as sound as any of her arguments. He was grateful to have been found by a scientist of her calibre.

Entrapta didn't have nightly clothes. She told Hordak that the smell of grease on her overalls helped her sleep better, imagining that she was near the machines. She understood the value of cleaning, of course, she simply preferred to do so in the morning.

There was also there differences in sleeping arrangements. Hordak required a padded slab on which to rest his deteriorating form. Entrapta was inexplicably happy in a nest of rags and bits of technology she could tinker with. Their respective positions were kept beside each other, in case of an incident, but entirely separate by nearly a full five centimetres.

He had been reading Entrapta's database on Etherian social behaviours, and learned that separate beds was typical for those not in a spousal relationship.

"Entrapta," He rumbled.

"Yeah?" She glanced up from the edge of her nest.

Prime did not kneel, and he would not kneel to anyone but Prime.

But one knee was not truly kneeling, and Entrapta was shorter than he - it was a reasonable accommodation.

Now, how had Prime done it? But that had been to a clone, these Etherians were far softer. After the first two explosions had wounded her, shielding her from harm had become a habit. A softer grip then, one hand more than enough with her smaller

jaw. And gentle touch - he had no idea how fragile these ones were in the face.

"Er, Hordak?" Her tone was mildly surprised, with faint notes of discomfort.

"Your research said that it was a sign of gratitude." Hordak explained, watching her draw back to lower her mask.

"It, er, is usually meant for romantic purposes." She echoed from behind the goggles as she curled down into her nest, drawing a blanket over her huddled form.

"Romantic?" Hordak growled, grunting exertion as he lowered onto his bunk. "What is romantic?" An unfamiliar word, like magic. "You will teach me this romantic." He decided.

"Oh!" Entrapta blinked. "Okay! You can be my partner to the All Princess Ball!"

Hordak paused. "Is that 'romantic'?" He probed.

"I think so?" Entrapta shrugged. "I've not really done it before."

"Then we shall learn together." Hordak declared. Then paused. "Will it involve more kissing?"

Entrapta hoped so.

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